Zabulistan–Zamindawar (cf. Chapter 5). Second, given the Shansabanis' origins in the nomad–urban continuum of seasonally transhumant and/or nomadic lifeways, the fissure between patron and patronage becomes a particularly informative space to explore.

Blair rightly noted that, "[i]n both form and intent, Ghurid architecture continues that of the Ghaznavids."[91] However, much needs to be differentiated in the processes of *how* these two architectural corpora came to be. We have established elsewhere in this volume that the Shansabanis can and should be distinguished from their immediate predecessors the Yamini–Ghaznavids in many respects (see esp. Chapter 1), perhaps in none more than architectural patronage. Beginning with the high-ranking Samanid *ghulam* Alptigin (d. AH 366/977 CE) and his successor Sabuktigin (d. AH 389/999 CE) – both considered progenitors of the Yamini–Ghaznavid dynasty – *all* of this royal house's scions had been reared in cosmopolitan and courtly Perso-Islamic surroundings. Although of Turkic ethnic and linguistic origins, these *ghulam*s had been incorporated into the Samanid court, witnessing its active encouragement of Arabic- and Persian-language writing in both secular and religious fields.[92] Characterizable at least initially as a Samanid "successor-state," the Ghaznavid dynasty continued to feel the benefits of maintaining Arabic-language bureaucracy, while the rulers themselves were knowledgeable in and patronized literary production in Persian (and also Arabic).[93] This overall investment in a cultural "footprint" further intertwined Zabulistan within the commercial, intellectual, and religious networks of greater Eurasia (see also Chapters 2 and 3).

The Ghaznavids' immersively courtly background could not form a more glaring contrast to the Shansabanis' obscure origins in seasonal transhumance and/or nomadism. Nevertheless, the Firuzkuh Shansabanis quickly learned the mechanisms of attaining and exercising contextually appropriate kingship, including the commissioning of magnificent architectural complexes such as Shah-i Mashhad, Chisht, and the Firuzkuh *jami'* complex and its renowned *minar* (the specific subjects of the present chapter). Based on the significant differences between these sets of imperial patrons, however, I suggest that the Shansabanis' imposing buildings were as much – if not more – the results of input from courtly intelligentsia and the actual craftspeople who fabricated them, as from their royal masters.

For the Shansabanis, their transhumant/nomadic pre-imperial milieu could have perhaps offered some opportunity to experience built forms. This would have occurred as they encountered settled environments along their seasonal routes of transhumance, which spanned the length of historical Ghur. Although again a modern parallel, it is nonetheless useful to note the visitations of migrating nomadic pastoralists to Sufi *khanaqah*s, particularly when these are located along their paths of movement and/or near their seasonal market areas.[94] Regular contact with such